

Case File: Bozeman-Area Junk Removal

*The valley has ~15 small haulers but only one with real brand gravity (Junk in the Trunk); the social field is nearly empty, pricing is opaque industry-wide, and Big Sky has no resident operator — the opening is a transparent-pricing, donation-first hauler that *owns* Big Sky and the construction wave, marketed through the exact Facebook community groups where these jobs are actually decided.*

28 June 2026 · Botman research orchestrator

Target: The small-operator junk removal landscape across Bozeman, Belgrade, Big Sky, and Three Forks, MT — competitor map, Facebook-positioning playbook, and national-service gap analysis for a pre-launch entrant (Chase's Junk Removal).

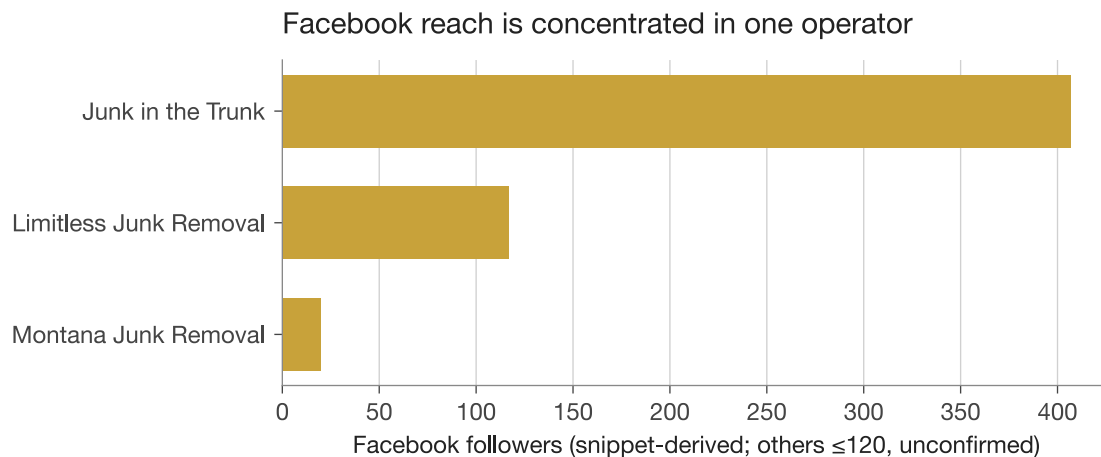
One-line takeaway: The valley has ~15 small haulers but only **one** with real brand gravity (Junk in the Trunk); the social field is nearly empty, pricing is opaque industry-wide, and **Big Sky has no resident operator** — the opening is a transparent-pricing, donation-first hauler that *owns* Big Sky and the construction wave, marketed through the exact Facebook community groups where these jobs are actually decided.

The Audit

Source-pool meta-analysis. This qualifies everything below — read it first.

The streets are half-lit. Two layers, very different quality:

- **Operator existence & service menus: SATURATED and reliable.** Five sub-agents triangulated ~15 genuine local haulers from their own sites, Facebook, BBB, Nextdoor, Thumbtack, and chamber listings. The map of *who exists and what they claim to do* is evidence: high.
- **Review counts, ratings, pricing, and consumer sentiment: BLOCKED and thin.** This is the load-bearing caveat. **Yelp, Google Business, Angi, and HomeAdvisor all returned HTTP 403** to every agent — no live ratings were retrievable. **Reddit (r/Bozeman) and Nextdoor blocked automated reads** — zero verbatim customer complaints were captured. **The Meta Ad Library returned 403** — no paid-ad activity could be confirmed for anyone. So: every review count here is **self-reported by the business** or pulled from a stale search snippet, and every “gap” is inferred from *infrastructure and geography*, not from a single customer actually saying “I couldn’t find anyone.”



Source: Botman research findings, 2026-06-28 — Yelp/Google/Meta Ad Library returned 403; treat as directional

What that means for you: The competitive *structure* is trustworthy. The competitive *reputation data* is not — treat all review numbers as claims, not facts, and verify the demand gaps by phone and by reading the Bozeman Facebook groups yourself before you bet money on them. A chorus of self-reported five-star counts is not a finding.

Pricing is a near-total blackout. Almost no local operator publishes a dollar figure — the market runs on “free quote.” Only the national broker **LoadUp** (~\$79/single item) and two dumpster outfits publish rates. That opacity is itself one of your biggest openings (see Worth Pulling).

What We Know

1. The operator map — who you’re actually up against

Confidence on *existence + service menu*: likelihood: almost_certain / evidence: high (each triangulated across ≥ 2 independent sources). Confidence on *review/rating figures*: evidence: low (self-reported or snippet-only; primary platforms blocked).

Tier 1 — The real competitors (dedicated junk haulers with brand presence):

Operator	Base	Owner	Serves Big Sky / Three Forks	Equipment edge	Reputation (UNVERIFIED)	Social
Junk in the Trunk	Bozeman/Belgrade	Lisa & Craig Gambrel (family)	Both	Truck(s)	“180-200+ 5-star” self-claim; BBB A, accredited 5/2025	FB ~407 (the leader)
Limitless Junk Removal (Garcia Hauling)	Bozeman	Allen Garcia + wife	Big Sky	Skid steer + mini excavator + 7×16 dump trailer	“110+ 5-star” self-claim	FB ~117
406 Removal & Hauling	Belgrade	“Bob” + crew	Both (dedicated town pages)	15-ft truck, trailer rentals	Snippet-only	FB active
Common Waste	Bozeman/regional	“John” (family)	Both	Dumpsters 10-40yd	None retrievable	—
Hustle Haulers	Belgrade	Taylor Gardent	No	—	Thumbtack 5.0 (3 reviews)	FB/IG
Lone Wolf Junk Removal	Bozeman	“Halsten” (solo)	Big Sky	—	Testimonials only	—
Mercury Junk Removal	Bozeman	David Hembrough (2 staff)	No	—	Thumbtack 5.0 (4 reviews)	Nextdoor (dormant)
Montana Junk Removal	Bozeman	Owner-op (est. 2018)	No	—	None retrievable	FB ~20 (dormant)
Last Best Junk Removal	Bozeman	Owner-op (new, 2025)	No	Truck + trailer	Angi 5.0	FB (new)
	Bozeman		No	—	Snippet-only	—

Operator	Base	Owner	Serves Big Sky / Three Forks	Equipment edge	Reputation (UNVERIFIED)	Social
Local Junk Removal & Moving		“Jeff S.” (est. 2018)				
Gallatin Demo & Removal	Bozeman	Veteran-owned	No	Demo crew	“5-star” self-claim	—
Bozeman Junk Removal	Bozeman	“New, locally owned”	No	—	None	FB/IG (@bjr59715)
Bozeman Junk Removal & Hauling LLC	Belgrade	Codey Allison	Both	—	None	Nextdoor only
Declutter USA	Bozeman	LGBTQ-owned	No	—	None	—
Lighthouse Junk Removal	Bozeman	Unknown	No	—	None	—

Tier 2 — Movers who also haul junk (secondary threat): Rock Steady Movers (Belgrade, est. 2017, local awards), Treasure State Movers (Beau & Christina), Mike’s Moving. Junk is an add-on for all three, not the core.

Tier 3 — Dumpster / utility (different lane, but they touch your market): L&L Site Services (Belgrade, veteran-owned, est. 2007, roll-off + curbside), Dumpster Rental of Bozeman, Dumpster Rentals Montana (published: 10yd \$535/wk → 40yd \$916/wk), Republic Services (national curbside utility).

Not real local competitors — don’t be fooled (evidence: high): LoadUp (national broker, routes to a contractor), AAA Rousse (Fort Lauderdale FL lead-gen with one phone number spanning 300+ MT miles), Bro’s Hauling / Royal Junk / Grunber (lead-gen & marketplaces), and **“Big Sky Junk Removal LLC” — which is actually in BILLINGS, 3.5 hours away.** The search results for “Big Sky junk removal” are badly polluted by this name collision and by lead-gen pages; a real Big Sky-focused brand would cut through fast.

2. The Facebook & social landscape — your highest-leverage opening

likelihood: likely / evidence: moderate (FB follower figures are snippet-derived; Ad Library blocked).

- **One operator has meaningful social proof, and it's modest.** Junk in the Trunk: ~407 FB followers, the only one with a real recommendation footprint. **Every other operator is under ~120 followers; two are effectively dormant (≤ 20).** No competitor could be confirmed running Meta ads.
- **The discovery channel is uncontested.** Junk-removal jobs here get decided in community-group threads — “anyone know a good junk hauler?” posts in **The Real Ask Bozeman, Ask Bozeman, Bozeman Buy/Sell/Trade**, and on **Nextdoor** (~53,500 Bozeman-area neighbors). No operator works these systematically.
- **Mechanics that rank you locally (2025-current):** FB Recommendations volume + recency; group posts get ~10× the organic reach of Page posts; Reels out-reach static posts 2-3×; the “Very Responsive” badge (90% replies <15 min) is free and earnable in week one; external links get throttled ~70-80% (use “DM for a quote”); and **Google Business review velocity** is now a primary local signal — recent reviews beat a big stale pile.

3. The national service menu & pricing models (the benchmark)

evidence: high (triangulated across chains, brokers, and operator-education sources, dated 2025-2026).

- **Full service taxonomy** runs from core haul-away through estate/hoarding/foreclosure clean-outs, construction & demolition debris, light demolition, garage/attic/basement, yard & storm debris, dumpster rental, e-waste, mattress & appliance/freon recycling, donation routing, commercial/property-management contracts, hot-tub removal, and junk-plus-move hybrids.
- **Dominant pricing model = volume (fraction-of-truck):** ~\$100-200 (1/8) → ~\$550-800 (full), with rural markets running 10-25% *below* national. Per-item (LoadUp’s model, ~\$79+ first item), hourly (\$75-150/two-person crew), and flat minimums (\$75-150) round it out. Standard surcharges: stairs/long-carry, heavy debris (concrete/tile per-ton), freon (\$25-75/unit), e-waste, mattress, same-day.
- **National trend that’s now table-stakes:** donation-first / landfill-diversion positioning (chains claiming 60-70% diversion) and **upfront online pricing**. The locals here have adopted *neither* at any visible level — that’s your wedge.

4. The Montana operating layer (what makes services viable here)

evidence: high for disposal facts (pulled directly from gallatin-solid-waste.org); evidence: high for growth/construction demand (multiple 2025-2026 sources).

- **Disposal reality:** Logan Landfill (Manhattan, ~25 mi from Bozeman) — MSW \$27/ton, light C&D \$48/ton, heavy C&D \$58/ton, **refrigerant appliance evac \$32/unit**, tires \$58/ton. Bozeman Convenience Site (in-town) is faster **but bans refrigerant appliances, full trailer/dump-truck loads, and concrete** — and is closed Sun and Mon, shutting at 3:30pm. **A single fridge forces a 50-min round trip to Logan.**
 - **Diversion partners:** Habitat ReStore (Belgrade), Pacific Steel (pays cash for scrap metal), Four Corners Recycling.
 - **Demand is structurally strong and growing:** Bozeman ~60k and +1.8%/yr; **Belgrade is the fastest-growing city in MT** with a development pipeline in the thousands of units (Middletown alone ~4,686); ~497 new-construction homes listed in 2025; **Big Sky in a \$150M+ resort build-out**; 74 homes sold >\$2M in 2025 (vs. 11 in 2019).
 - **Seasonality is a two-engine system:** valley peaks spring-summer (moves, remodels, cleanups); **Big Sky runs counter-seasonal** (winter resort season + year-round construction). Winter compresses Logan's hours and makes rural/ranch access hard.
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What Doesn't Add Up

Contested claims with a light hypothesis matrix. These are the spots where the evidence wobbles.

A. Junk in the Trunk's "180-200+ five-star reviews" vs. a BBB establishment date of Oct 2024.

Going from zero to ~200 reviews and BBB accreditation in well under a year is fast for this market.

- *H1* — *Rebrand of an older entity:* an existing operation re-formed under a new LLC, carrying its reputation. (Most likely — fits the family-business profile.) - *H2* — *Aggressive, systematic review-gathering:* genuinely new but disciplined about asking. (Plausible — and if so, it's *imitable*; it's their playbook, not a moat.) - *H3* — *Inflated/self-reported number:* the count is a website claim; Google was unverifiable (403). (Can't rule out.) - **Verdict:** likelihood: `roughly_even` between H1 and H2 / evidence: low. Either way, the takeaway holds: their lead is review-driven, recent, and **catchable** — not a structural moat. **Verify their actual Google count manually before treating it as the bar.**

B. "No junk hauler is based in Big Sky" — **proving a negative.** The Big Sky agent ran 50+ searches and found only EcoSmash (compaction; website 404, likely defunct) and Big Sky Bin Service (valet trash) physically there. - *H1* — *Genuinely no resident hauler:* the economics (1-hr haul, seasonal) deter local basing. (Most likely.) - *H2* — *A resident operator exists but is invisible*

online (word-of-mouth only). (Possible in a small resort town.) - **Verdict:** likelihood: likely / evidence: moderate. Strong enough to *plan around*, not strong enough to *bet the company on* — confirm by asking Big Sky property managers directly.

C. Out-of-state phone numbers on “local” operators. Bozeman Junk Removal & Hauling LLC (WA 360), Treasure State Movers (Chicago 630), Common Waste (FL 954 secondary). Could be relocated owners, VoIP, or national parents in local clothing. evidence: low — flagged, not resolved.

D. Quick Clear Junk Bozeman — operator or spam? One agent flagged the site as lead-gen with embedded gambling links; another logged it as a real operator. **Treat as suspect** until verified.

Worth Pulling

The small details that could crack the case open.

-  **Big Sky is the unguarded flank.** No resident hauler, no one targeting resort/HOA/property-management/construction-turnover work, and — critically — **not one operator advertises a Big Sky premium despite the hour-long drive.** The whole market is mispricing the most affluent, highest-willingness-to-pay corner of your service area. A Big Sky-anchored brand (even valley-based but *Big-Sky-first* in marketing and pricing) faces almost no direct competition. Caveat: EcoSmash’s apparent death is a warning that a pure Big Sky play has thin year-round volume — pair it with valley work.
 -  **Pricing transparency is wide open.** The entire local field hides behind “free quote.” A published per-item + volume price list (the LoadUp move, localized) would be a genuine differentiator in a market where every competitor makes you call to find out anything.
 -  **Donation-first is unclaimed.** National table-stakes; *nobody local owns it.* In environmentally-minded Bozeman, “we donate/recycle first, landfill last — here’s your receipt” (via Habitat ReStore + Pacific Steel) is both a margin play (lower tipping fees) and a marketing identity no competitor has taken.
 - **Limitless is the one to actually watch.** Skid steer + mini excavator + dump trailer means they can do land clearing, grading, and real demolition — jobs pure haulers can’t touch. They’re your most *capable* competitor even if JITT is the most *visible*.
 - **The recurring-revenue proof points exist.** Common Waste runs subscription pickup plans; Big Sky Bin Service runs \$35/mo valet trash. Recurring property-management/HOA contracts are being validated at the edges — nobody has consolidated them.
 - **The refrigerant-appliance trip is a productizable pain.** Because a single fridge forces a Logan run, a flat-rate “appliance & fridge pickup” that batches units and amortizes the trip is a clean, ownable offering.
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Loose Threads

Open questions and recommended follow-ups before you commit capital.

1. **Verify the real reputation bar.** Manually open Google Business + Yelp for Junk in the Trunk, Limitless, and 406 R&H and record *actual* review counts/ratings. The 403 wall means we never confirmed them.
 2. **Read the demand in the wild.** Spend an evening in The Real Ask Bozeman, Ask Bozeman, and r/Bozeman searching “junk,” “haul,” “cleanout.” Capture verbatim complaints and unmet asks — that’s the consumer voice this run couldn’t reach.
 3. **Phone-check Big Sky.** Call 3-5 Big Sky property managers / HOAs: who do they use for clean-outs and construction debris, and are they happy? Confirms or kills the #1 gap.
 4. **Re-confirm tipping fees by phone** (Logan 406-582-2492) before building any price model — the fee pages carry no “last updated” date.
 5. **Pin down equipment strategy.** Your pricing power on C&D and Big Sky jobs depends on whether you match Limitless’s heavy-equipment capability or stay a clean hauler. Decide early.
 6. **Set up cross-check later.** Perplexity cross-check was requested but `PERPLEXITY_API_KEY` is unset — see below.
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Evidence Locker

PRISMA-style search ledger

Sub-agent	Searches run	Key sources used	Blocked / barren
Local census — Bozeman/Belgrade	~42	Operator sites, BBB, Nextdoor, Thumbtack, chamber, Yelp snippets	Yelp/Google 403; Craigslist sparse; FB unauth
Local census — Big Sky/Three Forks	~52	Operator sites + dedicated town pages, BBB, FB, LoadUp	Yelp/Angi/HomeAdvisor 403; no resident Big Sky hauler
Facebook & social	~26	Operator FB pages (snippets), Meta/LocalIQ/practitioner docs, Nextdoor	Meta Ad Library 403; FB follower counts snippet-only; group sizes login-walled
National service menu & pricing	~26	1-800-GOT-JUNK, College HUNKS, Junk King, LoadUp, Junkluggers, House-CallPro, Jobber, FieldCamp, Dropcurb	Chain pricing intentionally opaque; r/junkremoval not directly reachable
Montana gap & context	~32	gallatinsolidwaste.org (primary), gallatinmt.gov, Habitat Bozeman, Pacific Steel, real-estate/census reporting	Reddit & Nextdoor blocked → no verbatim complaints; Yelp 403

Source quality summary

- **Primary (high trust):** Gallatin Solid Waste District (tipping fees, hours), operator own websites/BBB profiles (existence, services, ownership), county/census growth data.
- **Secondary (read between the marketing):** national-chain pages, operator-education sites (pricing benchmarks), Thumbtack/Angi snippets.
- **Suspect / downgraded:** all self-reported review counts; lead-gen sites (AAA Rousse, Bro's Hauling, Royal Junk); the Billings "Big Sky Junk Removal LLC" name-collision; Quick Clear Junk.
- **Could not access (the audit's core limitation):** Yelp, Google Business, Angi, HomeAdvisor (all 403); Reddit & Nextdoor reads; Meta Ad Library.

Representative sources

- gallatinsolidwaste.org/landfill-fees/, [/bcs-fees/](#), [/hours-and-late-fee-disposal-charge-policy](#)

- junkinhetrunkmt.com ; limitlessjunkremoval.biz ; 406rah.com ; commonwastewest.com ; lone-wolfjunkremoval.com ; hustlehaulersllc.com ; mtjunkremoval.com ; llsiteservices.com
- bbb.org (Junk in the Trunk; Bozeman Junk Removal & Hauling; Hustle Haulers)
- goloadup.com (national per-item pricing benchmark)
- 1800gotjunk.com, collegehunkshaulingjunk.com, junk-king.com, junkluggers.com (national service menu)
- housecallpro.com, getjobber.com, fieldcamp.ai, dropcurb.com (pricing-model benchmarks)
- business.nextdoor.com, localiq.com, hashmeta.com (FB/Nextdoor ranking mechanics)
- bozemanmagazine.com, dailymontanan.com, bigskyresort.com/2025 (growth & construction demand)

Cross-Check (Perplexity)

Unavailable this run. PERPLEXITY_API_KEY is not set in the environment, so the independent Perplexity Sonar second-opinion pass was skipped — not fabricated. To run it later: set the key, then `/cross-check --from-botman research-findings.md`.

Findings only. Verify the three loose threads marked 🔑 before you spend a dollar — the structure is solid, the reputation data is not.